

Sales Training — Session 28

Value, Price and the Seesaw.

Where the Deal Actually Lives.

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WHAT THIS SESSION IS A mental model for what's happening inside the buyer's head during a price conversation — and the move that lets a rep drop the price without burning down the value they spent the whole pitch building.

1. The seesaw — value on one side, price on the other

Imagine a seesaw inside the buyer's head. On one side sits value — everything they've heard about what they're getting. On the other side sits price — the number the rep just quoted. The buyer's entire decision-making process is the seesaw tipping back and forth between those two weights.

When value is heavy and price is light, the seesaw tips toward yes. When value is light and price is heavy, the seesaw tips toward no. Selling, in this model, is not about "convincing" — it's about managing the weights on each side of the lever.

"Price doesn't matter as much as you think. It only matters in the absence of value. Sell value. The seesaw will do the rest."

Most reps spend the call piling weight onto the value side — features, benefits, case studies, social proof. That's correct. The mistake comes at the price reveal — when the rep, sensing resistance, lifts weight off the value side by dropping the price. The seesaw immediately tips the wrong way, because the buyer now thinks the package was worth less than they were told.

2. The fair value gap — where the deal actually lives

Inside that seesaw is a specific zone — call it the fair value gap. It's the space between what the buyer believes the package is worth (perceived value) and what they actually have to pay (the price).

The buyer says yes inside this gap. They say no outside of it. If the price sits above the perceived value, the buyer feels ripped off. If the price sits well below the perceived value, the buyer feels suspicious — "why is it this cheap, what's wrong with it?"

The fair value gap is the sweet zone — "this is a fair price for what I'm getting, and I feel like I came out slightly ahead." That last clause is critical. Buyers want to feel like they won a little. Not a lot. A little.

"Put enough weight on value, get the price high enough where you've got perceived value. There's a line under that — the gap. They feel they beat you slightly. That's where the deal is made."

3. Why unilateral price drops are catastrophic

If the buyer says "I was thinking more like \$500" and the rep replies "sure, I can do that" — the rep has just done four damaging things in one breath:

- Told the buyer the original number was inflated — "so what was the real price all along?"
- Unwound the value the rep spent 45 minutes building — the buyer now mentally re-prices everything downwards.
- Removed the rep's negotiating room — there's nothing left to give in the next round.
- Signalled desperation — the rep needed the deal more than the buyer did.

Dropping the price by \$100 doesn't take \$100 of value off the package. It takes roughly 50% of value off — because the buyer's trust in the original quote evaporates. This is what Corie meant by "you've unraveled every part of the value proposition." Same money on paper. Half the integrity in the buyer's head.

4. The counterweight — what to add when you take price off

If a price drop alone destroys value, the rep needs to add weight to the value side at exactly the moment they remove weight from the price side. That added weight is called the counterweight. The most reliable counterweight is referrals.

The mechanism is simple. When the rep says "I can adjust the price, on one condition — that if we deliver, you give me five or six names of people in similar businesses," two things happen at once. Price goes down. Value (in the buyer's eyes) goes up. The buyer is now buying something more substantial than just the package — they're entering a small partnership.

"You're going to remove some price, and as you start putting the referral on, the value should be going up. When you take off some of the price and some of the value comes off with it, it should look pretty sweet — because in their head it will be off-balance slightly, in their favour."

That last phrase — "off-balance slightly, in their favour" — is the entire point. The buyer needs to feel like they got the better end of the trade. The rep, of course, also got the better end — referrals are worth far more than the price they cost — but the buyer doesn't see it that way, and they shouldn't. The asymmetry is hidden inside the trade.

5. Use the word "contingency" — not "discount"

Word choice carries weight on the seesaw. "Discount" is the wrong word. It tells the buyer the original price was puffed up, the rep had room to move all along, and they could probably extract more if they pushed harder. The value side of the seesaw immediately lightens.

"Contingency" (or "condition") tells the buyer the adjustment is conditional on something they're providing in return. The trade is symmetric. The package is still worth what it was —

they're just paying less because they're contributing referrals. Same money on the page. Completely different psychology.

"Look, I've got some fantastic news — I've got approval to give you the exact package you want, just under one contingency."

6. The script for the referral counterweight

The session walked through the move step by step. Reps should learn this verbatim and adapt the names — the structure is the same every time:

1. Buyer names a lower price. Rep says: "I don't think I can quite get there, but let me check with the director — give me 5 minutes."
2. Rep "calls the director" (in reality, just steps away — the gap is theatre). On return, rep says: "I've got approval to give you the exact package you want, just under one contingency."
3. Buyer asks what the contingency is. Rep says: "Most of my business comes from referrals. I'm wondering — do you know anyone in business that might benefit from what we do?"
4. Buyer will name 2–3 people instinctively. Rep cools them down: "Give me their names — just first names, no business names. I just need it for the director." Get to 5, 6, 7+ names.
5. Rep adds the close: "If we do a great job for you in 3–4 months, would you be happy to introduce me to them? I'd send you the email template — you literally just forward it."
6. Optional sweetener for high-value referrals: "If any of them sign up, I'll speak to the director about giving you a month off." Use sparingly.

7. The 16-referral story — what's possible

Corie's record on this move was 16 names from a single buyer. The deal price came down. The agency walked away with sixteen warm introductions to similar businesses — roughly 160 cold calls' worth of pipeline saved, with much higher conversion attached. The buyer felt like they'd taken the rep to the cleaners. They both won. The buyer just didn't notice that the rep won more.

Sixteen is the ceiling, not the floor. Most reps will land 3–7 names with consistent practice. That's still enough to make the trade asymmetric. The point isn't to chase 16 — it's to understand that the buyer has more referrals available than they'll spontaneously offer, and the rep's job is to make it easy for them to give up the list.

"You've got 16 people on the line here now — do you think it's too hard to ask them to send off 16 emails? No. And then I'd go one step further — if any of them sign up, I'll speak to the director about giving you a month off."

8. Why the buyer secretly wants the referral arrangement

On the surface, the buyer is just trading a list of names for a price reduction. Underneath, something more useful is happening — and reps who understand this layer close better.

The referral list functions as an insurance policy for the buyer. The rep has 16 reasons (or 7, or 5) to bust their ass on this account. If the rep underperforms, the buyer doesn't introduce them to anyone, and the rep loses the warm pipeline they negotiated for. The buyer, in other words, has just locked in unusually high attention from the agency for the next 3–4 months.

The rep should not say "this is an insurance policy for you" out loud — that breaks the spell. But the rep should understand it, and lean into the implicit message: "I have skin in the game now. You've made me responsible for your result." That framing is what makes the trade feel fair to the buyer.

9. When NOT to use the referral counterweight

This move is powerful, which means it has to be used in the right situations:

- Don't use it when the buyer's number is well below fair value. If they want \$200/month for a \$625 package, the gap is too wide for a referral trade to bridge. Walk away politely.
- Don't use it when the buyer isn't networked. A sole trader with no industry peers can't actually deliver the referrals. Use a different lever (longer contract, smaller package).
- Don't use it as a stand-in for selling value. If the buyer hasn't bought the value, dropping the price under contingency just looks like a confused discount. Build value first, then trade.
- Don't promise the contingency without delivering on the work. If the rep collects referrals and the campaign underperforms, the buyer's trust collapses and the referrals never come. The move only works when paired with real delivery.

10. Action items for the team

1. Memorise the seesaw model — value one side, price the other, fair value gap in between. Hold it in your head during every pitch.
2. Stop using the word "discount." Replace with "contingency" or "condition" — in every conversation, every email, every quote follow-up.
3. Practise the referral counterweight script (Section 6) verbatim with a partner before next Monday. Don't improvise the wording — it's been tested.
4. After every closed deal, schedule the 3–4 month referral call in your calendar at the time of close. Don't rely on memory.
5. Track referrals received per closed deal in a simple spreadsheet. Target: 3+ names per deal by end of month, 5+ by end of quarter.
6. Build the email template the rep would send to a buyer's contacts — make it a forward-ready, copy-paste piece so the buyer's friction is zero.

THE RULE OF THUMB Never take weight off price without putting weight back on value. Referrals are the weight. "Contingency" is the word. The buyer feels they won. The rep walks away with the pipeline.